DM ONLY — Menagerie control sheet

Starting layout: _____ Current: _____ Pair: _____

Layout	Alcove I	Alcove II	Alcove III	Alcove IV
A (book)	Illusion	Mimic	Construct	Real
B	Real	Construct	Illusion	Mimic
C	Construct	Real	Mimic	Illusion
D	Mimic	Illusion	Real	Construct

Wand reactions

Wand → / Content ↓	Bright Light	Poison (1 charge)	Acid (1 charge)	Mage Hand (lifts)
Illusion	Shadow stays frozen. Reveal.	"The mist drifts straight through the key." Reveal.	"The acid passes through and hisses on the wall behind." Reveal.	Gong, vapour. Reset.
Mimic	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	Gags and slumps. Reveal.	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	Bites the hand, lunges. Reset.
Construct	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	Casing melts, fuse dies. Reveal (disarmed).	Armed: explodes and resets. After Acid: harmless scrap; no reset, not the real key.
Real key	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	Success.

Reset

Advance A → B → C → D → A. Remove all reveal cards, return both charge tokens, and announce that the contents have moved. Keep alcove cards in place.

Hazards

Mimic: AC 12, HP 15, +5 bite; 1d8+2 piercing +2 acid (average 6 piercing). Mage Hand absorbs the bite. Murray can restrain it for 2 rounds. Armed construct: DC 12 Dex, 2d4 damage, half on success. Acid disarms it: lifting is safe and the door rejects the scrap without a reset. A reset rearms it. Illusion: gong, no damage. Retrieving an illusion, mimic or armed construct resets.

DM ONLY — Coaching & clue timing

Start neutrally

Four identical silver wolf-crest keys wait under arches. Four wands rest on a table. Describe each key the same way. Do not expose the reveal cards, plaque or crest.

2–3 minutes: orientation

“What happened to the last people here?” Describe scorches, tooth gouges and sticky residue beyond the brass studs, spread across all four alcoves. Point out the two single charge sockets.

5–6 minutes: character hook

“Scooby, anything on your sheet that a snack helps with?” Roll d20 +14 vs DC 17 (1–2 fail). On success: alive identifies the current mimic; fake identifies the current illusion. On failure: surge spent, no location or false clue, no reset; continue with wands or Murray’s lore. Neither identifies the real key. Use the current layout.

8–9 minutes: logic clue

Reveal the plaque after the rack search, or when dust is smeared away. Do not assign its verses to alcove numbers.

11 minutes, or reset after 10: emergency

Prompt Murray to tap with his bandage whip. Mimic: wet snore. Construct: ticking. Illusion: passes through key. Real: hollow brass bell. Give locations from the current layout. Accept a player’s clever early tap.

13–15 minutes

At 13 minutes the real key glows if needed. Finish by 15 minutes with a funny cost. Do not stall an early solve.

Keep tests fair

Use the reaction table’s identical words for identical outcomes. A plain result still conveys evidence. Collect Poison/Acid tokens before resolving the test. A reset clears every previous observation.

Source: Stations/Station_4_Mimic_Menagerie_Wands_and_Keys.md. This is a quick reference; use the station sheet for full adjudication.